

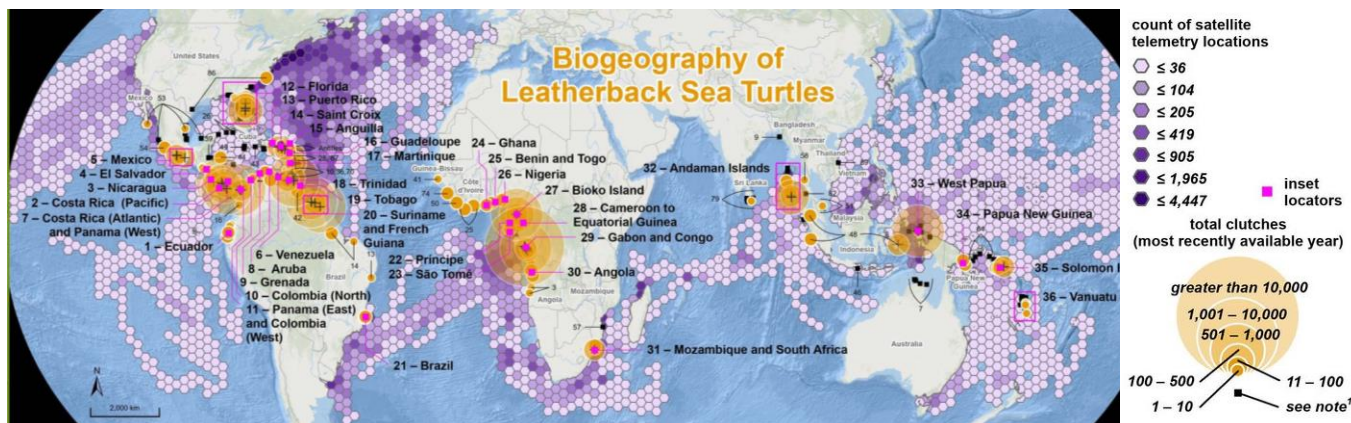
WORLD OCEANS DAY 2026

JUNE SPECIAL EDITION - ENDANGERED SPECIES IN WEST AFRICA

Issue 2: Leatherback Sea Turtle

Meet the Leatherback - World's Largest Sea Turtle

The Leatherback Sea Turtle (*Dermochelys coriacea*) is among the most remarkable marine species found in West African waters. Unlike other sea turtles, it does not have a hard shell. Instead, its body is covered by a unique leathery skin that allows it to dive deeper and travel farther than any other sea turtle. The leatherback is circumglobal and can be found in all world's oceans except Arctic and Antarctic. As the largest living sea turtle, the leatherback plays a vital role in maintaining healthy marine ecosystems by feeding on jellyfish and helping to keep marine food webs in balance.



Biogeography of Leatherback Sea Turtles. Retrieved from [SWOT Report, vol. XVIII \(2023\)](#)

Leatherback Populations Under Threat

Despite their ecological importance, leatherback turtles face numerous threats across West Africa, including accidental capture in fishing gear, plastic pollution, degradation of nesting beaches, and the impacts of climate change. These pressures have contributed to population declines in several areas. Leatherbacks are listed as **Vulnerable** by the [IUCN Red List of Threatened Species](#).

In commemoration of World Oceans Day 2026, WASMaN joins regional and global efforts to protect leatherback turtles and other endangered marine species. Through research, awareness creation, community engagement, and advocacy, WASMaN promotes the conservation of critical coastal and marine habitats.